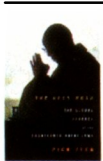


THE GLOBAL GURU

Pico Iyer, a seasoned observer of the Dalai Lama mystique, goes into the mind of the spiritual icon



THE OPEN ROAD: THE GLOBAL JOURNEY OF THE FOURTEENTH DALAI LAMA
by PICO IYER
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■ By Rajiv Mehrotra

The *Open Road* is an insightful, personal journey into the world of the Dalai Lama, standing tall at the ethical and moral centre of an interdependent globalised world. Pico Iyer rises above his already-considerable reputation as a travel writer and essayist to skillfully reveal layer after layer of the Dalai Lama's personality, philosophy and striving. With impeccable timing that must seem like divine serendipity to the faithful, the book has been published as its subject has moved centrestage following the brutal Chinese suppression of Tibetan protestors. If we are to believe in all that the Dalai Lama embodies—all that is good, true and just—he must ultimately succeed

For the Dalai Lama, approaching his 50th year in exile, and the continuing triumph of Chinese military and economic power, the ides of March 2008—after long years of hopelessness—brought both cheer and despair. The widespread protests by Tibetans in China despite the Government's Orwellian stranglehold and the demonstrations against the Olympic torch wherever it travelled in the free world, were a reminder that the Tibetan cause was alive. It was begging our collective conscience to stand up to Chinese obduracy and bullying. Ironically, it took images of violence on television screens around the globe to remind us of the singular power of a pacifist Buddhist monk. He has kept alive the cause of his people while living in exile as a guest of a foreign government. He has done this with a deep commitment to non-violence that is bred of a tradition that is as deceptively simple as the man himself. It is a rare story of a refugee community which is welcomed by its hosts even as

it is encouraged to retain its identity.

Inspired by Mahatma Gandhi, for whom the means were more important than the end, the Dalai Lama considers the motive behind one's actions—and that includes violence—more important. He argues, "Violence is fundamentally wrong. But in some exceptional circumstances, with an altruistic motive, when there is no other alternative, one can consciously and with full awareness of the personal karmic consequences, commit such an act."

The Dalai Lama prays that the "veils of ignorance" of the Chinese

Not wishing to embarrass the Government of India, he discouraged Tibetan NGOs from continuing their Free Tibet March from Dharamsala to Lhasa. A 'living Buddha', he admits to tears and overwhelming emotion as he sat with the prime minister of his elected Government in Exile as news of renewed violence in Tibet first trickled in. He does go on to reassure us that given his years of Buddhist practice and training, he was still able to distance himself enough from the unfolding present to get a good night's sleep.

The Dalai Lama reconciles seeming

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SCIENTIST OF MIND: The Dalai Lama

might lift, and asks us all, especially those Tibetans who are victims of Chinese oppression, to do so as well. He disappointed tens of thousands of Tibetans, particularly the younger generation, by refusing to support their violent protests against the Chinese in Tibet, even as he understood their frustration, nor was he willing to endorse a boycott of the Olympics he felt the Chinese people were entitled to host.

contradictions with remarkable ease. In pursuing the human rights of the Tibetan people and the preservation of their culture, he does not seek political independence, even as a negotiating position, but genuine autonomy and a commitment to working together with the "great Chinese people". He is a religious leader, believed by millions to be an incarnation of the Buddha, yet one who delights in recounting his frailties, one who counsels caution before abandoning one's faith even to